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A Blueprint for Writing a High School Essay

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Writing is an essential skill, especially during the high school years. As a parent, you know that learning to write well will prepare your student for college, careers, and communication in the adult world. But practicing writing can feel abstract, subjective, and even discouraging to teens, making writing a challenging skill to teach.

As a homeschool graduate, a writing tutor, and an AP® English teacher, I know that parents can teach this skill at home—and the easiest way to do this is by walking your students through writing their first essay!

You may find it helpful to start with this handy metaphor: writing a paper is kind of like building a home. Although it's a time-consuming process that requires lots of planning, effort, and patience, the results are rewarding. From early brainstorming to final touches, every step of the building process is important.

Laying Groundwork

Teaching students to write well often begins with creating a culture of words. This is like preparing the building site for a new home. My parents had wonderful ways of laying groundwork with words. You can try some of these, too:

- Encourage your children to read widely. This can begin well before high school! Introduce them to classics, historical fiction, biographies, and non-fiction on topics they find interesting. Invest in audiobooks to introduce a variety of narration methods. Incentivize reading by making books fun and relevant—prizes, privileges, or special outings can be powerful motivators!
- Use reading as a springboard for short, warm-up writing projects. Students can learn to summarize, describe, present an opinion, compare-and-contrast, etc., by writing a paragraph or two about a book they have just read. Social networkers might enjoy exchanging thoughts with other readers on a community platform such as [GoodReads.com](https://www.goodreads.com).
- Play games that revolve around words. Games can teach vocabulary, spelling, or sentence construction by blending these lessons with family fun. My family especially enjoys *Boggle*, *Balderdash*, and *You've Been Sentenced!* There are many more for your family to discover. Here

is a fun starting point: <https://www.goodhousekeeping.com/childrens-products/board-games/g19724764/best-word-board-games/>

STEP 1: CHOOSING A TOPIC

When the time comes for an actual writing assignment, your teen gets to brainstorm and envision the finished paper much like a family narrows the options to cast a vision for their dream home.

You can help your teen get started by identifying a topic that genuinely interests them—perhaps a sports team, popular film, clothing style, or political issue. Think outside the box to find a topic that uniquely motivates your teen.

Then have a conversation that allows your student to express their interest verbally. Ask leading questions: “Why does this topic interest you?” “What do you like about it, specifically?” “Why do you like it more than this other topic?”

The more specific the answer, the better. Then help convert the answer into an opinion or claim. This overarching opinion or claim gives direction to the project and becomes a ready-made thesis statement to shape the paper. Here are some examples of a good thesis sentence:

- **The Philadelphia Phillies have a brilliant offensive strategy** built around big-name hitters and veteran coaching.
- ***Mary Poppins Returns* recreates the elements fans loved in the original *Mary Poppins* film**—colorful characters, memorable songs, and magical adventures.
- **The global refugee crisis calls for a humanitarian response** that combines national security, true help for the needy, and a reasonable emigration timeline.

Notice that each example thesis has two parts. The bold portion states the writer’s claim without any specifics; it does the thesis’s job, but in a minimal way.

The second portion adds detail to the claim, providing depth and a preview of the points that will be developed later in the essay.

It can be challenging to craft a detailed thesis (also called a *closed thesis*) at first, but your student can perfect the skill through practice.

STEP 2: MAKING A PLAN

With this thesis statement, your teen has cast a vision for the essay, so it’s on to the outline. To return to the house-building metaphor, it’s now time to draw up blueprints!

Starting this phase can be challenging. If your student stares at the rest of the blank page in dismay, you can help them overcome writer's block by continuing your conversation.

Asking questions and jotting down bullet points is a helpful jump-start strategy. Encourage your teen to verbalize their opinions on the topic or list reasons for the claim they are making. Put each opinion or reason in a bullet point. As your student talks through their thought process, they will gain the confidence to convert their ideas into typed words.

Find creative ways to help your teen organize these bullet points to plan the paper's flow. For doodlers, let them draw bubble diagrams with favorite colored pens. If your student needs to be hands-on, give them a pile of sticky notes and a blank wall or kitchen counter. If your teen is a systematic, linear thinker, show them a traditional outline as a pattern. These diagrams, sticky notes, or bullet points turn into ready-made topic sentences for the essay's paragraphs.

STEP 3: STARTING THE DRAFT

Once the points are planned out, it's time to write a rough draft. Your student can use the blueprint they have made to start framing out the essay, starting with the *structure*—the way the essay is organized. Just like constructing a house, early progress may seem skeletal and painstakingly slow, but it will take shape with persistence.

A well-structured essay has four key components:

- *Introduction paragraph*—it sets the stage for the points that are coming. A good introduction often starts with a broad view of the topic and zooms in to a specific claim or thesis.
- *Thesis*—this is usually the last sentence in the introduction paragraph. It should reveal the essay's ultimate destination (the main point to be proven) and, ideally, sketch the route it will follow to get there (the detailed subpoints that prove the main point). See the example sentences under Step 1.
- *Body paragraphs*—each subpoint should be unpacked in its own body paragraph. Essays typically have two or three. These paragraphs work together to build a convincing case, showing why the thesis is true.
- *Conclusion paragraph*—it pulls all the points together and sums up the essay's main argument. A good conclusion leaves the reader with an interesting parting thought.

If building paragraphs is a hurdle for your student, these tips may help:

- *Begin with a topic sentence* that introduces the topic or point specific to this paragraph.
- *Provide evidence or reasoning* that unpacks the topic or explains why the point is sound.

- Use clear transitions and explanation to help the reader trace the train of thought and bridge any gaps between points.

STEP 4: EDITING MAKES PERFECT

When the draft is finished, the essay is well on its way to completion. But, like a newly framed and sheet-rocked home, it still needs a pleasing coat of paint and other finishing touches. This process of perfecting is what we call *editing*.

One key component of the editing process is attention to *style*. Style is like the paint color that gives a room its unique character. As your teen edits the rough draft, they should consider these factors that set their style apart.

- *Wording* should be clear and understandable. Are thoughts phrased in a way the reader can readily follow? Or are they cumbersome, awkward, or vague?
- *Vocabulary* should demonstrate proficiency. Are words used correctly? Do some sophisticated words appear?
- *Transitions* between thoughts or paragraphs should be clear and smooth. Can readers easily trace the progression from Point A to Point C? Or are they left confused by a leap in logic?
- *Sentence lengths and structures* should vary. Do all the sentences follow the same standard formula, or do they switch up the order of phrases and clauses? Does the reader want to keep reading? Are the metaphors or illustrations compelling?

Your teen should also pay attention to *grammar* and *mechanics*. Like doorknobs and light-switch covers, contractions and commas may not seem that important at first glance; but they can enhance or detract from the finished product your teen has labored to create.

As your young writer proofreads to check for grammatical errors, ask them to pay attention to things like capitalization, punctuation, verb tense consistency, complete sentence structure, and correct usage (absence of contractions, abbreviations, slang, etc.).

Find a proofreading checklist to help guide your teen, or make your own rubric! Look up one of the many grammar resources available online if either of you needs a refresher on these topics. The free grammar rules and entry-level quizzes at grammarbook.com would be great places to start!

Assessing and grading

When your teen has finished editing, the construction project is complete and ready for final inspection! You, as the parent, get to play the inspector's role.

Consult your grading rubric to help evaluate structure, content, style, and mechanics, along with other components discussed in this article.

Remember: not every essay deserves an A! Fair grading should evaluate more than your student's effort or intent. You can help prepare them for life after high school by giving honest feedback and pointing out mistakes. Healthy critique will empower them to grow as a writer and a young adult.

You've got this!

High school writing does not have to be scary—for the homeschooling student or parent! You *can* help your teen learn and practice writing skills at home.

HSLDA is here to support you every step of the way. Our team of high school consultants can give you as a member personalized advice about curriculum or other resources, and our slate of [HSLDA Online Academy English courses](#) can provide extra accountability, input, and reinforcement for your student's writing journey. Let us help you make homeschooling possible!